

Les Veilleurs — Crystal showcase (“aquarium”)

Tender documentation v02.3 · September 2026 · stainless-steel fabrication / metal joinery — request for constructive advice and price estimate

1. What this is

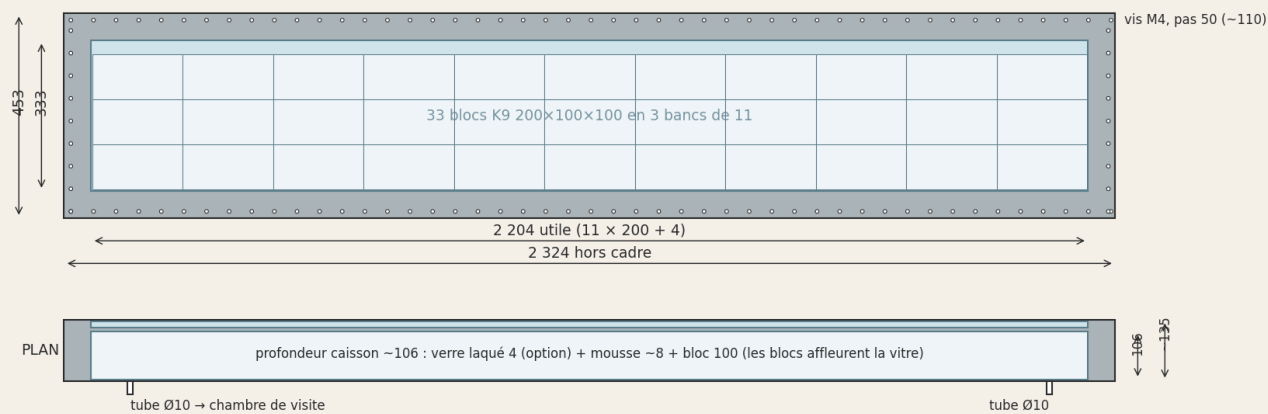
A permanent artwork on the Belgian coast (Beaufort 27, North Sea). Set into its stone base, a niche displays 33 laser-engraved optical crystal blocks on a black background behind a glass pane, in a dry-nitrogen atmosphere that protects them from sea humidity. We are looking for a workshop to build this niche: a welded, airtight stainless-steel box and its removable glazed cover. It is a one-off, hand-built piece meant to last decades outdoors and to be opened and serviced on site. The dimensions below are our proposal; your view on what would be simpler, safer or cheaper to make interests us as much as your price.

2. Main dimensions

Item	Dimension / value	Note
Usable inner cavity L × H × D	2,204 × 333 × ~106 mm	11 blocks of 200 per row + 4 mm shims; 3 rows of 100 + 3 mm top clearance + 30 mm reserve; depth: black background 4 + compressed foam 8 + block 100 – the blocks touch the glass, 6 mm in front of the frame face
Box overall (sheet)	2,324 × 453 × ~138 mm	= 60 mm flat frame around the cavity; 138 = sheet → front face of the bar = stone face
Niche in the stone base	rebate ≈ 64 × 32 all around	the box is embedded in the stone; the rebate takes frame + bar (4 mm clearance), the stone face is flush with the glass
Visible frame on the front	60 mm	the artist wants it as discreet as possible: 50 mm welcome if the rebate allows
Laminated low-iron glass 66.2, anti-reflective	≈ 2,264 × 393 × 13 mm — ≈ 29 kg	2 × 6 mm low-iron + PVB; anti-reflective coating on the outer face; polished edges
K9 crystal blocks	33 × (200 × 100 × 100) — ≈ 166 kg	supplied and installed by us, on site
Loaded mass	≈ 350 kg	box ≈ 60, frame ≈ 26, clamping bars ≈ 63, glass ≈ 29, blocks ≈ 166
Clamping screws	≈ 110 × M4×30 countersunk Torx, 50 mm pitch	no screw passes through the glass
Sealing	EPDM cord Ø10 compressed ~30 % in a 2 mm groove	the bar's shoulder sets the compression, not the screw torque

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03 — Vue de face et plan cotés, 3 × 11 blocs (mm)



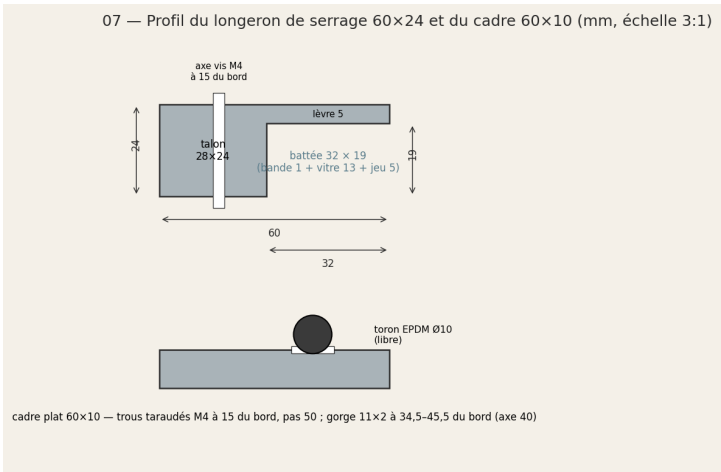
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3. Part-by-part description

3.1 Box (316L stainless, 3 mm sheet) — Sheet bent into a U (back + top and bottom walls), inner radius ≤ 3 mm. Two 3 mm end plates welded with a continuous seam, inner seams ground flush: the cavity must stay smooth, the blocks slide against the walls. Stiffeners on the outside only: 3 horizontal and 4 vertical 40×40×4 angles, stitch-welded (30/150). The back must not deflect more than 1 mm under 170 kg of distributed blocks. Two Ø10 × 1 tube stubs welded into the upper back wall at both ends, 200 mm straight, plain ends (compression fitting). Two removable M8 lifting lugs on top.

3.2 Front frame (60×10 stainless flat bar) — Welded all around the opening, mitred or lapped corners, then the front face dressed after welding: flatness ≤ 0.3 mm/m (this is the seal's bearing face). M4 tapped holes, axis 15 mm from the outer edge, 50 mm pitch, two holes 25 mm from each corner. Cord locating groove: 11 wide, 2 deep, axis 40 mm from the outer edge (one third of the width from the inner edge, away from the glass edge), continuous, R10 rounded corners.

3.3 Cover: four machined clamping bars (316L stainless, 60×24) — Profile: solid 28×24 shoulder bearing on the frame, 32×19 rebate on the inner side receiving the glass (1 mm rubber strip + 13 mm + clearance), 5 mm lip on the front. Countersunk M4 holes matching the tapped holes. Corner joint to be proposed by the workshop (dowelled-and-bonded mitre, or corners machined from solid). Visible finish: brushed or polished, sample to be agreed.



3.4 Glass and seating in the rebate — Laminated low-iron glass 66.2: two 6 mm low-iron panes (e.g. AGC Clearvision, Saint-Gobain Diamant, Pilkington Optiwhite) laminated with two clear PVB layers, i.e. 13 mm.

Anti-reflective coating on the outer face (face 1) — durable magnetron coating such as AGC Clearsight, Pilkington OptiView or Glas Trösch Luxar Classic — so the engravings stay legible under the North Sea sky; no coating on the inner face, where the blocks bear directly. Polished edges. No bonding: the glass sits in the rebate on a **self-adhesive rubber strip about 1 mm thick and 30 mm wide**, stuck to the rebate floor of the bar; no glass-to-metal contact, the glass stays removable. The glass may come from your usual glazier or from ours: please say which in your reply.

3.5 Seal and screws — Solid EPDM cord Ø10 vulcanised into a continuous frame to the groove dimensions (+ 1 spare). M4×30 countersunk Torx T20 A4 stainless screws, tightened crosswise, about 2 N·m; the bar's shoulder bottoms on the frame 5 mm above the groove floor, so seal compression is the same everywhere whatever the enthusiasm of the person tightening.

3.6 Option: LED strip at the top of the box — A sealed LED profile (IP67, 24 V, ~3 W, 3000 K, length $\approx 2,100$ mm) fixed under the top wall, inside the cavity, for downward grazing light on the blocks. We supply the profile; we ask you to price its fixing (two rails or lugs welded under the top wall, 3 mm reserve) and a third sealed Ø6 stub in the upper back wall for the cable, with stainless cable gland.

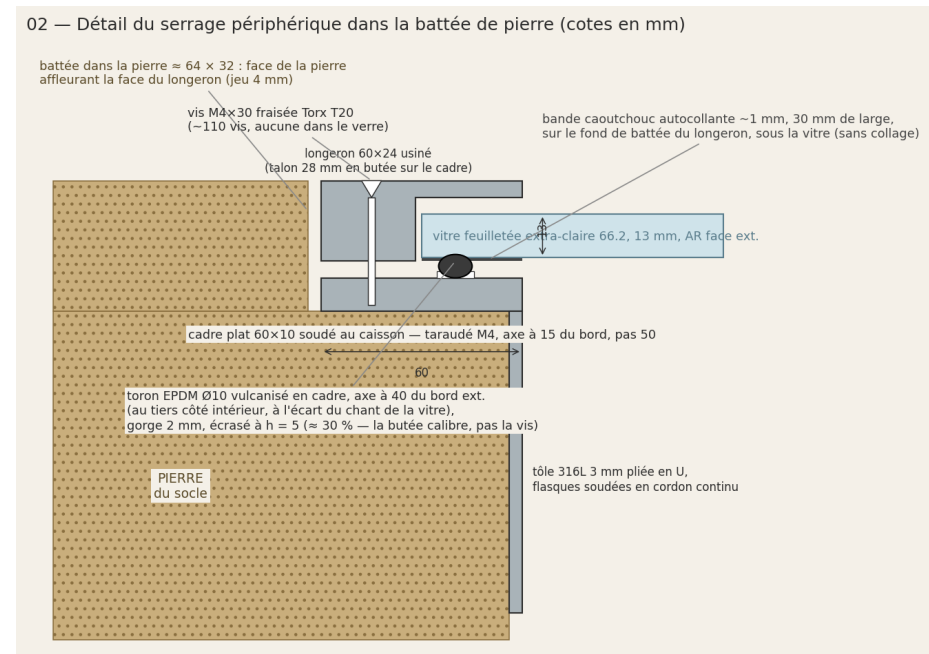
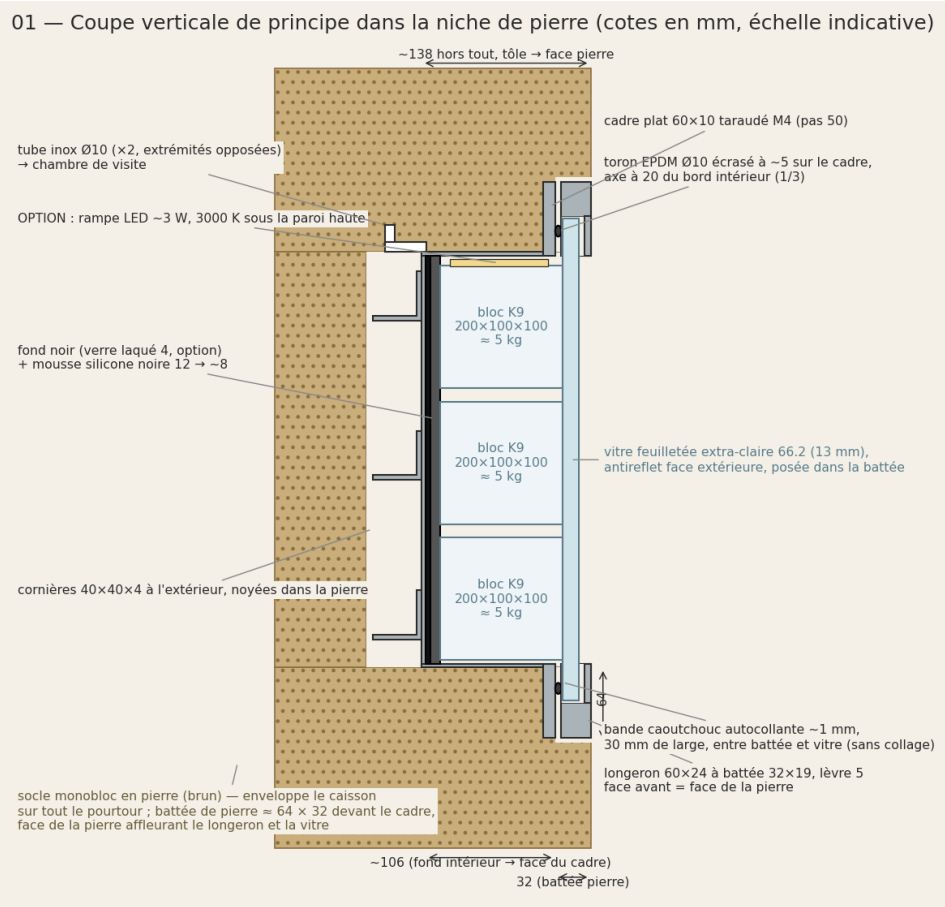
3.7 Niche in the stone — The box is embedded in the monolithic stone base all around (bottom, top, back, sides). In front of the frame the stone is cut back by a rebate about 64 mm wide and 32 mm deep that takes the frame and the bar with 4 mm clearance, so the stone face is flush with the bar face and the glass. This rebate is cut by the stone workshop from your final dimensions.

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3.8 Not in your scope — Black background (4 mm lacquered glass or black foam), 12 mm closed-cell silicone foam at the back, end shims, blocks, the LED profile itself, valves, desiccant and pressure-balancing bladder in the service chamber, grouting into the base: supplied and installed by us.

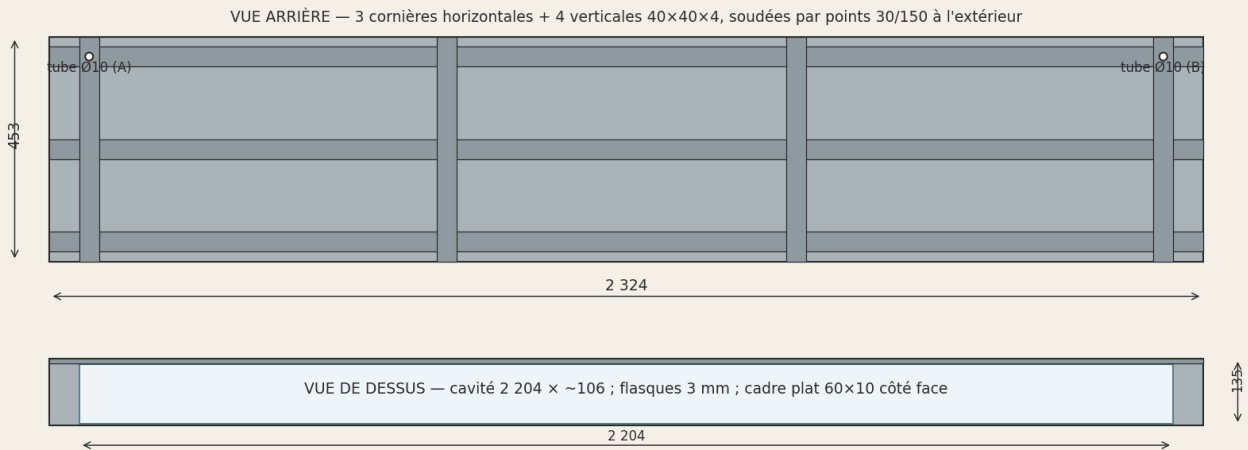
4. Drawings

Drawings are labelled in French; dimensions are in millimetres.

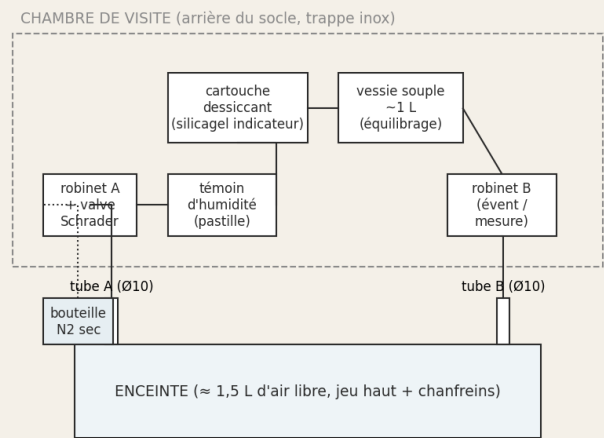


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06 — Caisson soudé : vue arrière (cornières extérieures) et vue de dessus (mm)



04 — Circuit de conditionnement d'air : azote sec, équilibrage, dessiccant, essais

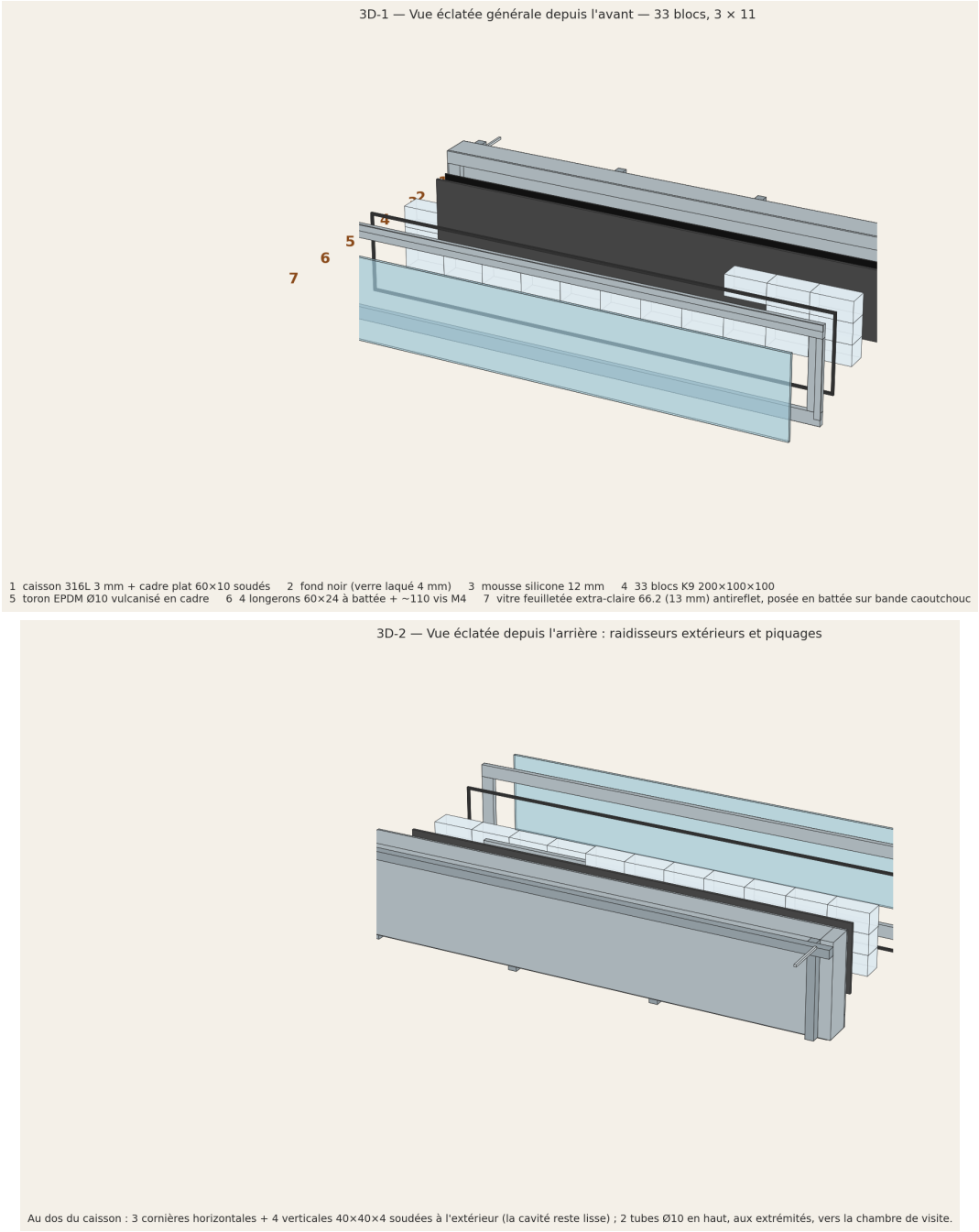


Fermeture : balayage azote sec A → B (10 volumes), fermer B puis A ; la vessie absorbe la respiration thermique (~10 %) ; recette : tirer -0,2 bar par la valve, fermer, lire la remontée — critère perte < 50 mbar / 24 h. Re-balayage sans démontage.

The gas circuit is shown to explain what the two tubes are for; it is not in your scope.

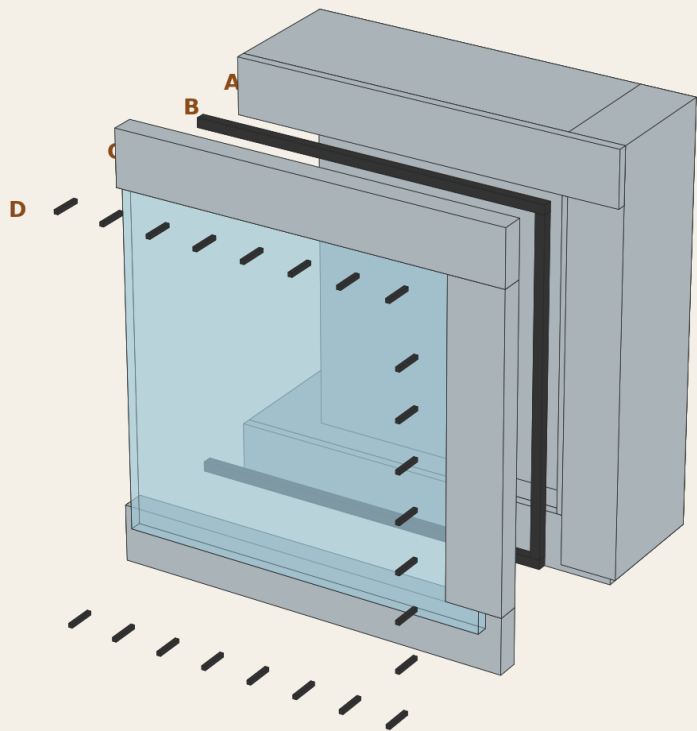
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4 bis. Exploded 3D views



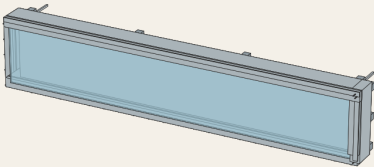
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3D-4 — Détail d'angle éclaté : cadre, toron, longeron à battée, vitre, vis



A cadre plat 60×10 soudé au caisson, taraudé M4 (pas 50, axe à 15 du bord), gorge 11×2
B toron EPDM Ø10 vulcanisé en cadre C longeron 60×24 à battée 32×19, vitre 13 mm sur bande caoutchouc autocollante 1 mm D vis M4×30 fraisées Torx T20

3D-3 — Ensemble assemblé (caisson vide, couvercle vissé)



Cadre visible 60 mm, vis fraisées Torx en façade (pas 50) — aucune vis ne traverse le verre ; le couvercle se démonte d'une pièce.

5. Indicative bill of materials

Ref.	Description	Material	Qty	Dimensions / note
1	U-bent sheet (back + top + bottom)	316L 3 mm	1	blank ≈ 2,324 × (135+453+135)
2	End plates	316L 3 mm	2	453 × 135, continuous seam

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Ref.	Description	Material	Qty	Dimensions / note
3	External stiffening angles	316L 40×40×4	7	3 × 2,324 + 4 × 453
4	Front flat frame	316L 60×10	≈ 5.6 m	M4 tapped 50 pitch, 11×2 groove, face dressed
5	Rebated clamping bars	316L 60×24 machined	4	2 × 2,324 + 2 × 453 (corners to define)
6	Laminated low-iron AR glass	66.2 low-iron, AR face 1	1	≈ 2,264 × 393, polished edges
7	Self-adhesive rubber strip (EPDM or silicone) 30 × 1 mm	rubber	≈ 6 m	on the rebate floor of the bar
8	EPDM cord Ø10 vulcanised frame	EPDM 70 Sh	1 + 1	perimeter ≈ 5.5 m
9	M4×30 countersunk Torx T20 screws	A4 stainless	≈ 115	crosswise tightening
10	Ø10×1 tube stubs	316L	2	200 mm, plain ends
11	Removable lifting lugs	stainless M8	2	on top
12	LED option: Ø6 stub + gland + profile fixings	316L	1	LED profile supplied by us

6. What we ask of you

Package	Content	To price
A — Box	refs 1 to 4, 10, 11: bending, airtight welding, stiffeners, dressed frame, tapping, groove	firm price + lead time
B — Cover	ref. 5: 4 machined bars, corner joint, holes, finish	firm price + lead time
C — Glazing	refs 6 and 7: laminated low-iron AR glass and rubber strip (glass by you or your glazier)	price, or "excluded" if you prefer we supply it
D — Seal and screws	refs 8 and 9	price
E — Dry test	cover screwed on without blocks, -0.2 bar through the tubes, 24 h hold (loss < 50 mbar)	price, or included
Option 1	visible frame reduced to 50 mm (50×10 flat + 50×24 bar, 24 rebate)	extra / saving, feasibility
Option 2	visible finish of the bars: brushed / mirror polished	extra
Option 3	LED strip at the top of the box: fixings under the top wall + sealed Ø6 stub (ref. 12)	extra
Delivery	empty box and dismounted cover, protected, to a stone workshop (Belgium or Switzerland, to be confirmed)	transport price or ex works

7. We would value your view on

- 3 mm bent sheet + external angles: enough for back flatness, or would you prefer 4 mm?
- Dressing the frame after welding: machining, or is hand rectification enough for ≤ 0.3 mm/m?
- Corner joint of the bars: mitre, corners machined from solid, or a welded frame machined as one piece?
- Solid cord (30 %) or hollow tubular cord (50 %): which lasts better outdoors?
- Standard or tamper-resistant (TR) Torx for the front screws?
- Anything that, in your view, simplifies fabrication without changing the look: discreet frame, no screw in the glass, demountable.

8. Schedule and next steps

Step	Timing
Your constructive advice and price estimate	within 3 weeks

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Step	Timing
Artist's approval, then dimensioned execution drawings (PDF + STEP/DXF)	2 to 3 weeks
Firm price and order	on receipt of the drawings
Fabrication and dry test in the workshop	4 to 6 weeks after order
Delivery to the base (main workshop)	to be agreed together, winter 2026-2027

A 200 mm sample of clamping bar with cord, rubber strip and a piece of glass would be a good first step: tell us if you can make it and at what price.

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